

Age and Membership on Bahá'í Institutions

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THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

20 February 2022

To a National Spiritual Assembly

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

The Universal House of Justice has observed that several of your members are of an advanced age. We have been asked to convey to you the following.

As you are aware, with respect to age, the Writings do not specify an upper age limit for service on the institutions, and the House of Justice has made no decision in this regard. And in the matter of resignation from Bahá'í institutions, decision-making has been guided by the principles initially laid down by the Guardian and elaborated by the House of Justice that resignation is discouraged. Those who are called upon to serve on the institutions of the Faith are to endeavor to uphold the verdict of the electors and lend their share to the service of the Faith, regarding their membership as a “sacred obligation” that is “gladly and confidently accepted.”

Recognizing the toll that age can take on the capacity for service of even the most consecrated friends, however, the House of Justice has in recent years provided additional guidance. For example, it has called upon electors to take into account age as one factor in their determination for whom to vote. It has also permitted those believers who pass the age of seventy to approach their Assemblies and ask to be relieved of their membership, and has advised their Assemblies to acquiesce to this request, unless special circumstances exist that would render such a decision inopportune....

Be assured of the prayers of the House of Justice in the Holy Shrines on your behalf.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]